SHEEP'S MILK RICOTTA-FILLED OCCHI WITH LEMON AND BOTTARGA

SERVES	TOTAL TIME
6-8	**1 h plus the dough rest**

INGREDIENTS

348 g	Sheep's milk ricotta, whipped
348 g	Cow's milk ricotta
quantity not given	Salt
1 batch	Egg dough
75 g	Unsalted butter, cold and cubed
1	Lemon, peel finely chopped and pith removed
1/4 lobe	Bottarga

METHOD

1. Put both ricottas in a food processor and pulse only until the mixture turns as smooth as cake frosting and picks up a sheen. Stop there. Keep going and it breaks.
2. Scrape it into a bowl and salt it until it tastes properly seasoned. Refrigerate until you shape the pasta.
3. Make 90 occhi from the egg dough and the ricotta filling.
4. Salt a large pot of water heavily and bring it to the boil.
5. Add the occhi, then pull the heat back so the water holds a gentle simmer instead of a rolling boil. Shape and filling are both fragile and high heat will tear them. Cook 1 to 2 minutes, until the thickest closure point is tender and the filling runs when you cut one open.
6. While they cook, set a large saute pan over very low heat with the butter and 2 to 3 ladles of pasta water, 115 g to 170 g. Swirl to emulsify.
7. Carry the pasta over with a spider and swirl 30 to 45 seconds to marry, turning the pieces gently with a spoon so every side gets coated. A splash of pasta water loosens the sauce if it tightens. It is ready when it clings with a gloss.
8. Lay the occhi out in a single layer on a platter or on plates. Slacken what is left in the pan with a few drops of pasta water and spoon it over. Finish with the chopped lemon peel and a generous grating of bottarga from a Microplane.

NOTES

Look for grey mullet bottarga. It runs milder and less fishy than the other kinds.
Over-processing breaks the ricotta. Pulse only to the point where it looks like cake frosting and shines.
The sheep's milk ricotta goes in whipped, the cow's milk ricotta as it comes.
Fish alongside cheese is no transgression in the Italian south, where ricotta and cured roe are both staples.
Occhi are thin at the closure. Keep the water at a simmer or they split and lose the filling.

FILLING

Sheep's and Cow's Milk Ricotta Filling

INGREDIENTS

348 g	Sheep's milk ricotta, whipped
348 g	Cow's milk ricotta
quantity not given	Salt

METHOD

1. Put both ricottas in a food processor and pulse only until the mixture turns as smooth as cake frosting and picks up a sheen. Stop there. Keep going and it breaks.
2. Scrape it into a bowl and salt it until it tastes properly seasoned. Refrigerate until you shape the pasta.

NOTES

The sheep's milk ricotta goes in whipped, the cow's milk ricotta as it comes.
Cake frosting is the texture to aim for. Past that point the mixture splits and will not pipe.
Season it on the generous side. It should taste well seasoned in the bowl, before any pasta or sauce dilutes it.

SHAPE

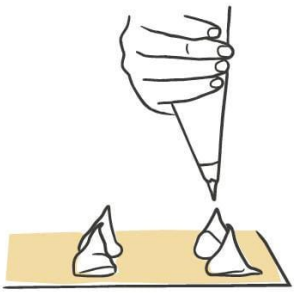
Occhi

Region: New York City. The author's own shape, with no confirmed Italian original / Rest: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered in the refrigerator

METHOD

1. Make your chosen egg-based dough, then roll and sheet it.
2. Dust a wooden board with 00 flour. Cover a sheet pan with parchment, then dust the parchment with semolina.
3. Trim the sheets to 18-inch lengths with a knife and cut away the ragged edges. Save the scraps for soup. Keep the sheets under plastic wrap or a towel.
4. Lay one sheet on the board. Using a pastry bag cut to a 1-inch opening, pipe mounds of filling roughly 1 1/2 inches across and 1/2 inch high in an even run down the sheet, leaving about 1 1/2 inches between mounds.
5. If the dough feels dry rather than moderately tacky, mist it with a spray bottle held 8 to 10 inches above the board so the second sheet will stick. Skip this if the dough is already tacky.
6. Lay a second sheet gently over the first, edges lined up and no wrinkles.
7. Press around each mound with your two index fingers to push out the air pockets. For insurance, flip a #30 (1 1/8-inch) plain round cutter to its dull side and press over each mound again to expel the last of the air and even up the circle.
8. Cut each piece with a #40 (1 1/2-inch) plain round cutter, pressing straight down with your palm flat on top of the cutter, then twisting the cutter clockwise under that pressure to finish the cut. The sealed piece carries only a very small border.
9. Lift the sheets from one end to peel away the surrounding scrap. Discard it or save it for soup.
10. Set the pieces on the prepared pan in a single layer and dust the pan again with semolina.
11. Repeat with the remaining sheets.
12. Refrigerate uncovered for 45 minutes to 1 hour to dry. Covered pieces sweat and get too wet. To hold longer, lay plastic wrap loosely over the pan and refrigerate up to 8 hours.

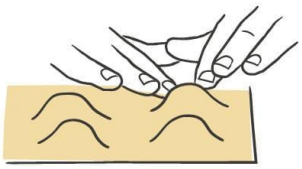
SHAPING



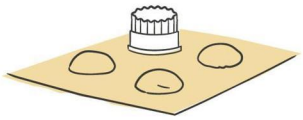
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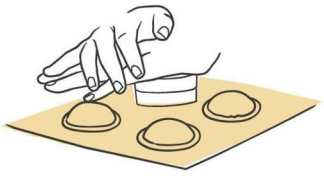
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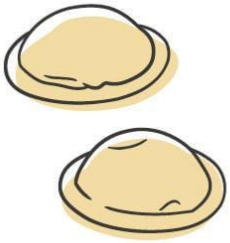
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NOTES

Two-sheet construction from 18-inch sheets, same as ravioli.
Filling per piece: a mound 1 1/2 inches across and 1/2 inch high, piped through a 1-inch opening.
Spacing: mounds sit 1 1/2 inches apart, tighter than the 2 inches used for ravioli.
Cutters: a #30 (1 1/8-inch) plain round cutter used dull side down to expel air and round the mound, then a #40 (1 1/2-inch) plain round cutter to cut. The cutting diameter matches the mound width exactly, and the book notes the sealed piece carries only a very small border.
Cutting technique: press down with a flat palm, then rotate clockwise under pressure to guarantee a clean full cut.
Air is pressed out twice, first with two fingers and then with the dull cutter.
Storage: 45 minutes to 1 hour uncovered to dry, then up to 8 hours refrigerated under loose plastic.
Served at the author's restaurant with a sheep's milk ricotta filling and a butter, lemon zest, and bottarga sauce. Otherwise as versatile as ravioli.

DOUGH

Egg Dough

Makes: 954 g / Active Time: 8-10 min kneading / Rest: 30 min minimum, wrapped

INGREDIENTS

500 g	Tipo 00 flour
454 g	Egg yolks
as needed	Extra 00 flour for kneading
up to 1 tbsp, only if dry	Room-temperature water

METHOD

1. Mix the yolks lightly, without beating them.
2. Mound the flour on a wooden surface and open a well 5 to 6 inches across. Wider than that and the walls collapse.
3. Add half the yolks, drawing in flour from the inner wall with a fork, working round the circumference.
4. Add the rest the same way. If the wall breaks, scrape the escape back into the flour until the mass holds itself.
5. Knead 8 to 10 minutes: press down and away with the heel of your hand, rotate 180 degrees, fold, repeat. Scrape your hands and the board as you go.
6. Add water a tablespoon at a time only if it stays dry and refuses to come together.
7. Stop when it is smooth, firm, and springs back slightly when poked. The texture to aim for is Play-Doh.
8. Wrap and rest at least 30 minutes before rolling.

NOTES

454 g of yolks is roughly 24 to 26 eggs, so plan what the whites are for.
Yolks only, no whites and no whole eggs, which is what makes this rich and tender rather than elastic.
Dry winter air is the usual reason it will not come together. Flour the board sparingly, since excess dries it out.
Keeps 24 hours. Chilled overnight, pull it out 20 minutes before rolling.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

NOTES _____

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